

A stranded ship on the dried-up bed of the Aral Sea. The loss of such a large body of water has had a devastating effect on agriculture, climate, and the local fishing industry.

Water scarcity

There are two types of water scarcity. Physical water scarcity affects regions that naturally do not have plentiful water, such as North Africa, the Arabian Peninsula, large areas of central and south Asia, northern China, and the southwest United States. In contrast, economic water scarcity occurs when water is available but the infrastructure does not exist to utilize it. This is the situation in much of sub-Saharan Africa and parts of Central America. People living in these areas may have to spend hours each day